

INFORMATION REPORT INFORMATION REPORT

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SUBJECT Report on Conversations With Soviet Scientists on Subject of Unidentified Flying Objects in the USSR

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1.

2. He visited [redacted] who was noncommittal on the subject of UFO's. The scientist who served as translator, a radio astronomer, emphatically stated that he knew of no sightings of UFO's in the USSR and added with a laugh that if they were only seen in the US, they must be of Soviet origin.
3. At the [redacted] one of the astronomers mentioned that she had heard of some sightings of unidentified objects near the Caucasus. She was unaware of any study being made of them but was open-minded on the subject.
4. The [redacted] main visit was to [redacted] who was very interested in the problem. He had read Menzies' book (which has been translated into Russian) but did not accept his conclusions. [redacted] knew of some sightings in the northern part of the USSR, but said that reports of such sightings are not printed in Soviet newspapers because they are not regarded as scientific observations. (Comment: this is interesting in view of the readiness of Soviet newspapers to print rather fantastic reports of hypotheses and "observations" suggested by the more imaginative members of the scientific community. Apparently some official sanction is needed.) [redacted] has been interested in US reports of UFO's and readily accepts their reality. In fact, it is his personal opinion that the UFO's may originate on Venus. He is well aware of the negative effect of "enlightened" scientific opinion on the interpretation of questionable observations as he has had personal

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experience of this effect. (Comment: [REDACTED])

5. At the [REDACTED], little interest is shown in the UFO question. [REDACTED] mentioned that he and several other astronomers had been out in the countryside one evening and had seen a curious, reddish object flashing through the sky that they were convinced was neither a satellite nor a meteorite. However, their immediate interpretation was that this object might have been a fragment of a satellite or rocket returning from orbit, burning up in the atmosphere. [REDACTED] thought that UFO's had been seen in the USSR but he could not be specific as to locations and characteristics.
6. At the [REDACTED] again little interest was shown. One of the astronomers, [REDACTED] was with the group mentioned by [REDACTED] and confirmed the observation of a peculiar object. He did not discuss the experience in detail but clearly had been struck by the possibility that the object might have been a "saucer."
7. At the [REDACTED] there was considerable interest. The institute includes [REDACTED] presided over by [REDACTED]. However, the initial discussion of the problem was with the director of the institute, [REDACTED]. He too had read Menzel's book, but considered it an adequate treatment of the subject which he consequently felt was closed. He indicated that no observations of UFO's had been made by his staff and that they had received no reports of such observations. However, when the [REDACTED] proceeded to indicate the results of McDonald's critical study of the problem, [REDACTED] readily conceded that there might be more to it and concluded by stating that it was "clearly still an open question."
8. Another astronomer mentioned that in the northern part of Kazakhstan there had been repeated sightings of ball lightning. [REDACTED] had sent a team out to investigate and discovered that what was being seen were reflections of automobile headlights from an inversion layer.
9. Later, a discussion was held with [REDACTED]. He was not very impressed with Menzel's book, but was also not impressed with the significance of the phenomenon. It is possible that some interest was kindled that might lead to additional investigations.
10. A stellar spectroscopist, [REDACTED] was also interested in this problem. [REDACTED] She was also dissatisfied with Menzel's book and felt that there was definitely an opportunity for additional research.
11. The general feeling one gets is that no official treatment of the UFO problem has been given in the USSR. Instead people refer to the US work, principally Menzel's book, to demonstrate the absence of real scientific problems. At the same time, there is an almost universal awareness of the history and characteristics of the phenomenon often associated with considerable interest. The result is that a demonstration of the inadequacy of US Official explanations coupled with some proof of the reality of the observations might excite enthusiasm more rapidly among Soviet astronomers than among their US counterparts who are more strongly influenced by the official ridicule associated with UFO's in the US.